# Helping students understand course expectations and procedures

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D15-S1

Use a short guided activity to help students find and interpret the information they need to participate in your course. Explain where current expectations are recorded and check understanding through practical questions. This guide covers course procedures; use D10 for interpreting individual assignment expectations.

## When to use this

Use at the start of a course and revisit the relevant information before unfamiliar activities or assessments. Students may know the subject but be unfamiliar with this institution's systems or expectations.

## How to guide students through course information

- Before class, check that the course guide, learning platform and linked procedures agree. Resolve conflicting information or explain who can clarify it.
- Show the main location for course information. Open one section and model finding an answer rather than reading every page aloud.
- Give pairs three or four questions to answer using the actual course materials. Allow quiet individual preparation first.
- Ask students to show where they found each answer and explain what they would do. Clarify misunderstandings and show the relevant wording.
- Leave a short reference with direct links and the contact route for unresolved questions. Revisit the information when it becomes relevant.

**Example wording**

"Open the course information page. With a partner, find how to submit work, where feedback appears and how to ask about an assignment. Note the link or heading for each answer. If something is unclear, write the question so we can resolve it."

**Check what students can do: Ask** "Where would you look for feedback?" or "What would you do if two deadlines appear different?" Invite several responses and offer a written route for questions. Explain unfamiliar institutional terms as they arise.

## Adaptable course information activity

Replace the prompts below with questions that match your course. Check each answer against current institutional requirements before sharing.

**Find the information:** Where are the current course schedule and preparation tasks? Record the page or heading.

**Explain the action:** How will you submit the first assignment and check that submission succeeded?

**Locate feedback:** Where and when should you expect feedback, and whom should you ask if it is missing?

**Ask for clarification:** How can you ask a question about a course task? What information should you include?

**Respond to a problem:** Where is the official process for reporting a problem that affects assessment?

**Teacher follow through:** Use responses to identify unclear wording or navigation problems. Publish clarifications in the normal course location so everyone can access them. Do not rely on students remembering an explanation given only once.

## Supporting Sources

Briggs, N. B. (n.d.). *First day of class*. University of Illinois Chicago, Center for the Advancement of Teaching Excellence.